It is being hailed as the new miracle medication. The reason semaglutide caught everyone's fancy was in its dual benefit—not only does it aid insulin production, it also helps the body lose 10-15 per cent of its weight by curbing hunger and promoting a feeling of satiety. Danish pharma giant Novo Nordisk presented, in three avatars, the injectable Ozempic, its oral version Rybelsus (both approved for treatment of diabetes) and Wegovy, an injectable approved specifically for weight loss. "It suited me so well," says 48-year-old Anuradha Verma (name changed), the wife of a Mumbai-based businessman, who has been spending her "shopping allowance" to go to Dubai every two weeks since June 2023 to source Ozempic. Diagnosed with diabetes four years ago, the drug has been a life-saver for Verma. "Not only is my blood sugar under control, I have also shed eight kilos since I began taking it," she says. On March 8, the US Food and Drug Administration (FDA) approved Wegovy for treating adults with cardiovascular disease (CVD) as well.

That can only be good news in a country that is the diabetes capital of the world, and which, along with the US and China, was found to be among the countries with "the largest absolute numbers of adults with obesity in 2022", and whose population is also susceptible to early onset of heart disease. The Indian Council of Medical Research and the India Diabetes (ICMR-INDIAB) Study published in 2023 estimated 101 million people in India to be suffering from diabetes in 2021 and another 136 million with pre-diabetes. According to the Global Burden of Disease (GBD) study, CVD cases doubled from 25.7 million in 1990 to 54.5 million in 2016. At 272 per 100,000 population, India's age-standardised CVD death rate is higher than the world average of 235 per 100,000. A report of the World Economic Forum and Harvard School of Public Health in 2014 estimated that the economic losses India would suffer on account of CVD between 2012 and 2030 would be approximately $2.17 trillion (Rs 180 lakh crore, in today's terms).

And obesity can be the underlying factor for both diabetes and CVD. According to the latest National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5) data, 24 per cent of women and 23 per cent of men in India are overweight or obese. The World Health Organization defines obesity as an abnormal or excessive accumulation of fat. It is measured by the body mass index or BMI—over 25 makes you overweight and over 30, obese. Worse, 56.7 per cent women and 47.7 per cent men have abdominal obesity. "Abdominal obesity makes it harder for your pancreas to produce insulin and puts pressure on many other organs," says Dr Ritesh Gupta, director, Fortis Hospital for Diabetes and Endocrinology.

So, when Danish pharma giant Novo Nordisk launched Ozempic in the US in 2017, it wasn't long before India's Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) approved oral semaglutide Rybelsus for use in the treatment of Type 2 diabetes in adults in India, along with exercise and diet. Launched in India in January 2022,

# SEMAGLUTIDE FAQs

## WHAT IS SEMAGLUTIDE?

**It belongs to a class of drugs called GLP-1 (glucagon-like peptide 1) agonists,** which mimics the action of the naturally-occurring hormone and aids insulin production, curbs appetite and promotes a feeling of satiety

## WHAT IS IT USED FOR?

**Treatment of Type 2 diabetes, and help the body lose weight by 10 to 15 per cent.** Studies have also shown that it reduces inflammation and improves heart health

## WHY IS SEMAGLUTIDE BETTER THAN OTHER DIABETES MEDICATIONS?

- **Like metformin, the treatment for diabetes in India so far, semaglutide is useful for people with insulin insensitivity**
- **Semaglutide injectables have been found to be more superior than insulin injections when it comes to managing blood sugar. They also have to be taken once a week and, unlike insulin, the dose does not have to be calculated every time**




- **There is no danger of low sugar either with semaglutide medication, which has been found to be the case with insulin, which can induce hypoglycaemia**
- **In addition, insulin also has weight-gaining properties, which is why it is unsuitable in obese people, without dietary or lifestyle changes. And while metformin may not lead to gain in weight, it has no effect on weight loss either**